

Can Dependence on China Motivate Industrial Policy? Experimental Evidence from the Biden Era

Kishore Gawande
University of Texas at Austin
Kishore.Gawande@mcombs.utexas.edu

Nathan M. Jensen
University of Texas at Austin
natemjensen@austin.utexas.edu

Rachel L. Wellhausen*
University of Texas at Austin
rwellhausen@utexas.edu

September 2026

Abstract

The United States and other states around the world are enacting major industrial policies, including support for semiconductors and green energy transitions. These policies involve subsidies and domestic content requirements that generate meaningful domestic distributional effects and are often motivated by the goal of generating quality jobs. At the same time, an overriding message for contemporary industrial policy in the United States is the need to reduce dependence on China. We examine how the public responds to different policy frames in an original survey experiment conducted in the United States during the Biden administration. On semiconductors, Republicans approve at lower rates than Democrats in the control condition. However, a China-dependence frame moves Republicans about 30 percentage points toward approval and closes the partisan gap. While a jobs frame increases aggregate support, its effect is comparatively modest and does not close the partisan gap. The same China-dependence frame does not detectably move support for solar subsidies in a parallel experiment, which suggests that the frame's reach is limited by ex ante partisan support for a policy. Results suggest that elites in both parties have reason to justify industrial policy by pointing to China.

Keywords: Industrial policy; United States; Semiconductors; Solar

Acknowledgements: For discussion and support, we thank Jenna Salzman, Daron Shaw, Pat McDonald, and the Civitas Institute at the University of Texas at Austin. *Corresponding author.

Introduction

A global backlash against globalization has coincided with the rise of industrial policy. In the United States, the role of government in business has been changed through the passage of new industrial policy legislation. Biden's signature legislative successes, including the 2022 CHIPS and Science Act, the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law, and the Inflation Reduction Act (IRA), contained elements of trade protection, including numerous "Buy American" provisions, as well as subsidies for new producers. This coupling of trade protectionism and industrial policy allows political parties to position themselves as pro-manufacturing, in an attempt to woo blue-collar workers (Osgood 2023). Job creation is the long-standing justification for protection, and its appeal to voters is not in question.

At the same time, the conversation around U.S. industrial policy concerns more than jobs. There is an increasing use of anti-China rhetoric, positioning China as an economic and national security threat. This trend has been ongoing since China's 2001 entry to the World Trade Organization (WTO), and it found its earliest audience among conservative-leaning Republicans (Donnelly 2024). Yet the recent bipartisan popularity of China-dependence framing is unmistakable (Luo and Van Assche 2023; Donnelly 2024; Bauerle Danzman 2026). Anecdotal evidence of anti-China rhetoric during the Democratic Biden administration (2021-2025) is abundant. White House press releases targeted unfair Chinese trade practices, which the Biden administration used as motivation to raise preexisting Chinese tariffs from 25 percent to 50 percent and to add a number of non-tariff barriers.¹ A 2024 Rose Garden speech in which Biden announced new Chinese tariffs is representative of the Democratic rhetoric around economic relations with China; it is worth quoting at length.

"For years, the Chinese government has poured state money into Chinese companies across a whole range of industries: steel and aluminum, semiconductors, electric vehicles, solar panels — the industries of the future... China heavily subsidized all these products, pushing Chinese companies to produce far more than the rest of the world can absorb. And then dumping the excess products onto the market at unfairly low prices, driving other manufacturers around the world out of business."²

Biden's focus is on Chinese state money flowing into specific "industries of the future" as a threat to the United States, motivating the choice of a tit-for-tat response in using U.S. industrial policy in a counteracting way. The CHIPS and Science Act passed the Senate in July 2022 with 17 Republican votes and the House with 24.³ The Inflation Reduction Act passed the same Congress two weeks later without a Republican vote in either chamber. Republican votes for the

¹ <https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2024/05/16/fact-sheet-biden-harris-administration-takes-action-to-strengthen-american-solar-manufacturing-and-protect-manufacturers-and-workers-from-chinas-unfair-trade-practices/>

² <https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefing-room/speeches-remarks/2024/05/14/remarks-by-president-biden-remarks-by-president-biden-on-his-actions-to-protect-american-workers-and-businesses-from-chinas-unfair-trade-practices/>

³ Senate roll call votes 271 (27 July 2022, H.R. 4346, 64-33) and 325 (7 August 2022, H.R. 5376, 50-50 with the Vice President voting yea), 117th Congress, second session, [senate.gov](https://www.senate.gov); House roll calls 404 (28 July 2022, 243-187) and 420 (12 August 2022, 220-207), [clerk.house.gov](https://www.house.gov).

semiconductor law, in a Congress otherwise divided along party lines, show that support for it crossed party lines among elites.

How does elite framing around industrial policy play with the U.S. public? If industrial policy begins as protectionist trade policy, then job creation and preservation is its natural justification. The ascendance among elites of anti-foreign-dependence rhetoric, and anti-China rhetoric in particular, suggests that they hold a working theory of public opinion in which this justification appeals to voters. Given the bipartisan use of anti-China rhetoric, we expect that both parties use it to appeal to their own constituencies. Might it also have cross-partisan appeal? In our context: can China-dependence framing of the Democratic Biden administration’s signature legislation motivate out-partisan support?

We explore these questions with survey experiments on a nationally representative sample during the Biden administration. Motivated by President Biden’s own “industries of the future” list, we first probe respondent support for U.S. government investment in semiconductor production, per the CHIPS and Science Act. We test both a job-creation and a China-dependence framing of the policy, and find that both have significant aggregate impacts alone and in combination. However, what is most striking is that effects of the China-dependence frame are driven by increases in *Republican* support, disproportionately shifting Republican respondents out of the middle category and into approval. Further, the positive, Republican-specific effects of the China-dependence frame do not appear for the jobs frame.

Recruiting out-party support for an administration’s signature policy is likely especially difficult in a time of intense polarization. A second experiment in the same survey asks whether this recruitment holds when the public is already divided by party on the policy itself. Specifically, we parallel the same question block but in this case on government support for solar panels, which was a component of the Inflation Reduction Act (IRA). Support for the green transition is sharply divided by party (Gustafson et al. 2019; Mayer and Smith 2024). We test the effects of China-dependence, jobs, and an environmental frame on solar panel industrial policy, and find null results, in aggregate and by partisan subgroup. The contrast suggests that a China-dependence frame can recruit the out-party where partisan positions on the policy are not yet fixed, and that no frame we tested detectably moves a policy on which the public has already sorted by party.

A growing literature considers what it is about China in particular that affects opinion among contemporary U.S. audiences (Mansfield and Mutz 2009; Carnegie and Gaikwad 2022; Ballard-Rosa, Goldstein, and Rudra 2024; Clark, Kreps, and Rao 2025). Our study contributes to this literature by shining light on a likely scope condition for the effectiveness of a China-dependence frame, despite its broad popularity. On one hand, a China-dependence frame can move opinion among the respondents least likely to support an administration’s policy, the partisan out-group, at a magnitude that a more traditional job-creation frame does not. On the other hand, this effect may reach its limits in a polarized era on a policy on which the public has already sorted by party.

In what follows, we situate our study in literature linking industrial policy and anti-globalization politics; characterize our Biden era setting; introduce the research design; and present results and robustness tests pointing to the next questions to be answered.

The Link Between Industrial Policy and Anti-Globalization

Globalization backlash in general, and trade backlash in particular, is well-documented (Walter 2021). This backlash in the United States predates the “China Shock” that began with China’s 2001 entry to the WTO. Goldstein and Gulotty (2021) provide a historical overview of how early U.S. support for the creation and maintenance of the global trade system eroded over time. The initial emphasis on supporting exporters alienated domestic labor, and the lack of institutions to support workers through “embedded liberalism” contributed to growing animosity toward global trade. While Goldstein and Gulotty (2021) focus on declining support for the GATT/WTO regime, declining support also anticipates many of the policy changes seen during both the first and second Trump administrations.

The globalization backlash, as well as the rise of populism, is partially attributed to non-material, sociotropic factors (Mansfield and Mutz 2009) and the efforts of political elites to capitalize on those factors (Guisinger 2017). Ballard-Rosa, Goldstein, and Rudra (2024) find compelling evidence that elite messages and perceptions of unfair trade practices have major implications for trade preferences in the United States. At the same time, the U.S. government has stepped back from negotiating and signing formal treaty-based trade agreements. This is not only a Trump phenomenon; while in the Trump era the rhetoric is around “trade deals,” in the Biden era the U.S. Trade Representative saw the goal as “creating new and innovative trade arrangements.”⁴ Thus, the inputs into individual-level trade preferences, and the outputs in terms of national-level trade policy, both appear to be evolving.

We enter the story here, to question economic preferences in this more complex context. Industrial policy has seen a reemergence in policy circles and the academic literature (Juhász, Lane, and Rodrik 2024). U.S. politicians now mention industrial policy by name, and broad bipartisan constituencies see it as an appropriate means to grow U.S. national power. Justifications for industrial policy have typically been rooted in economic and domestic job-creation motivations (Rodrik 2014; Osgood 2023). However, there is increasing evidence that elites are invoking broader motivations, such as supporting goals such as environmental protection (Allan, Lewis, and Oatley 2021) or securing access to resources such as critical minerals (Allan and Nahm 2025). Broadly, there is an increasing use of industrial policy either for or under the guise of national security (Weiss 2014; Farrell and Newman 2019; Wijaya and Jayasuriya 2024). Bauerle Danzman (2026) argues that a national security framing can be powerful enough to limit the usefulness to firms of lobbying against resulting trade protectionism or export restrictions.

The recent turn toward industrial policy in the United States combines economic justifications with environmental and national security ones. For example, green policies, which are often framed in the context of climate change and the regulation of polluting industries, have received added or replacement frames characterizing them as efforts to reshore production to the United States and create high-quality jobs. Stokes and Warshaw (2017) find partisan differences in the effectiveness of different green policy frames. In particular, Republicans respond more positively to job creation than environmental frames for renewable energy policies. Feldman and Hart (2018) find that Republican support for low-carbon energy policies is higher when framed as

⁴ E.g. <https://ustr.gov/about-us/policy-offices/press-office/press-releases/2024/march/ustr-releases-president-bidens-2024-trade-policy-agenda-and-2023-annual-report>

reducing energy dependence, with no parallel framing effects among Democrats. Carnegie and Gaikwad (2022) also provide evidence that dependence and national security concerns shape contemporary public opinion; their U.S. respondents prefer trade with allies over trade with adversaries. Our study builds on this and other recent work examining the influence of nationalism on industrial policy (Donnelly 2024). Our China-dependence frame names China and states the dependence claim explicitly; we think such a message about dependence on China carries a security meaning even when it uses no security language.

Growing literatures examining questions around industrial policy, public opinion, and partisanship reinforce what we have long known about partisanship as an enduring and powerful force in U.S. politics. For example, Chong and Druckman (2013) argue that individuals' responses to frames and counter-frames are strongly influenced by their partisan identities. Druckman, Peterson, and Slothuus (2013) further show that increasing elite polarization around an issue strengthens individuals' reliance on partisan cues when forming opinions. Parties also own issues, and the public has tended to rate Republicans as the party better able to handle national security (Petrocik 1996; Egan 2013). A frame that moves a policy into the security category may therefore reach Republicans on an issue their own party is seen to own.

What our study does is facilitate crossovers of scholarship on industrial policy and partisan effects. Motivated by real-world policies and elite framing choices, we test an economic justification for industrial policy against a dependence justification. Our primary focus is on the China-dependence justification, given its prominence in contemporary discourse. We ask which justification moves the partisan out-group toward a policy identified with the other party's president, and whether the answer holds when the public is already sorted by party on the policy at issue. To answer, we examine two signature legislative achievements on which the public was divided by party to markedly different degrees.

Setting: Biden-Era Industrial Policy

Two defining pieces of legislation during the Biden administration are archetypes of the contemporary resurgence of industrial policy in the United States and the world. The 2022 *CHIPS and Science Act*⁵ and the 2022 *U.S. Inflation Reduction Act (IRA)* are national-level policies that redirect monetary and other resources to promote some industries over others, and invoke broadly defined national security interests.

In 2022, the U.S. Congress enacted the CHIPS and Science Act. The CHIPS Act combined multiple proposed bills to subsidize both the production and research and development of semiconductors in the United States (Sutter, Sargent, and Singh 2023). It was designed to have several intended impacts on economic integration. In particular, it directly incentivized the reshoring of semiconductor manufacturing. While Taiwan has dominated semiconductor manufacturing, China's investments in and subsequent growth in the industry reinforced political motivations to invest at home. The CHIPS Act restricted new investments in China and a limited number of other "countries of concern" for a period of ten years. As a result, Luo and Van Assche (2023) identify this legislation as marking a shift from economic liberalism toward techno-

⁵ The 2022 law funded programs that Congress had authorized without money in the fiscal year 2021 defense authorization bill (Public Law 116-283).

nationalism—a strategy that includes not only subsidies but also export controls designed to decouple or de-risk supply chains from China.

In 2022, the *U.S. Inflation Reduction Act (IRA)* focused its industrial policy elements on promoting the green transition. The IRA’s environmental goals are deeply partisan in the current era, and the party-line vote coincides with the subsequent Trump administration’s immediate attention to rolling back the IRA. Our second set of survey questions explores support for solar panel manufacturing in the context of the IRA.

The partisan passage of this legislation mirrors broader trends in society. Renewable energy policy has become increasingly polarized in the United States. In a June 2023 Pew survey, 90 percent of Democrats prioritized developing renewable energy over expanding fossil fuel production, while a 58 percent majority of Republicans prioritized fossil fuels (Kennedy, Funk, and Tyson 2023). This polarization can be further magnified by policy changes (Gustafson et al. 2019) or elite messaging (Mayer and Smith 2024). Solar panel manufacturing policy serves as our case of a polarized industrial policy.

Less research has specifically examined public opinion towards semiconductors. One poll, a Politico/Morning Consult poll fielded in 2022 prior to the enactment of the CHIPS Act, found strong bipartisan support for the act. In this poll 68 percent of Democrats, 62 percent of Republicans, and 63 percent of Independents supported this act.⁶ In an experimental study, Clark, Kreps, and Rao (2025) find few partisan differences in support for semiconductor incentives.⁷

The two industries differ in more than the coalitions that passed their subsidies. Solar panels are a mature technology traded as a commodity, whereas semiconductors are an emerging technology with direct military uses. Solar policy carries climate valence, and semiconductor policy does not. China already leads world production of solar panels, and it is a challenger in advanced semiconductors. Our design holds one policy of each type and cannot separate these differences from partisan sorting or from one another. Which of these differences governs the public’s response is a question for a design that treats the qualities of an industry, rather than the framing of a policy, as the object of manipulation. Our goal in this paper is to document whether job and China-dependence framing shapes support for these policies. In the next section, we introduce our research design.

Research Design

Our aim is to examine how different frames shape U.S. public support for industrial policies and the protectionism inherent in them, with specific emphasis on the role of China-dependence framing. We deployed survey experiments in a nationally representative Civitas/YouGov survey of 1,200 U.S. adults, fielded from 5-11 March 2024 (during the Biden administration, while he was the presumptive Democratic candidate for the 2024 election).⁸ Respondents were matched to a sampling frame incorporating gender, age, race, and education, based on the American

⁶ <https://www.americanprogressaction.org/article/whats-the-point-americans-support-the-chips-and-science-act/>

⁷ Clark, Kreps, and Rao (2025) find null results on an experimental treatment varying China or South Korea as the country from which semiconductor manufacturing would be reshored. Our design includes a China cue; we find effects of both it and partisanship in shaping respondent views.

⁸ Unfortunately, circumstances were such that we did not formally pre-register our experiments.

Community Survey (ACS) and other supplements that take into account factors such as 2020 U.S. presidential vote. Party identification is the seven-point item, with Independents who lean toward a party coded as partisans.⁹

First, we embedded an experiment drawing on the content of the CHIPS Act. Our key treatment primes reduced dependence on China, which we refer to as the China-dependence frame. The treatment states the anti-China argument in the form elites use to justify industrial policy, as a case for reducing reliance on China. Given the rhetoric used around the enactment of the CHIPS Act, not to mention well-established findings from various literatures, we also prime job creation.

All respondents received the information: “The United States Congress has passed legislation encouraging investment in the semiconductor industry, especially chip manufacturing.” A control group did not receive further information, whereas three treatment groups received messaging on China, jobs, and an additive treatment.

China: This US federal government support for producing semiconductor chips in the United States will help the United States be less dependent on other countries like China.

Jobs: This US federal government support for producing semiconductor chips in the United States will create thousands of American jobs.

China + Jobs: This US federal government support [will help the United States be less dependent on other countries like China] and [will create thousands of American jobs].

Respondents were then asked, “How much do you support or oppose the US federal government enacting these types of policies?” on a five-point scale, with “don’t know” as a sixth option.

Second, we embedded a parallel design drawing on the IRA. All respondents read: “The United States Congress has passed legislation encouraging investment in the renewable energy industry, especially solar panel manufacturing.” The China and Jobs treatments are parallel. We also add a third Climate treatment and expand the additive treatment to take it into account.

China: This US federal government support for producing solar panels in the United States will help the United States be less dependent on other countries like China.

Jobs: This US federal government support for producing solar panels in the United States will create thousands of American jobs.

Climate: This US federal government support for producing solar panels in the United States will help the United States address climate change.

China + Jobs + Climate: This US federal government support for producing solar panels in the United States [will help the United States be less dependent on other countries like China], [will create thousands of American jobs], and [will help the United States address climate change].

We want to highlight a few design choices. First, we do not mention the CHIPS Act or the IRA by name, as whether or not the respondent knows the laws by name is irrelevant. We also want to prime only a specific element of each piece of legislation to reduce the potential for

⁹ Results are robust to coding Independents who lean toward a party as Other rather than as partisans.

confounders, so we focus on semiconductor chips and solar panel manufacturing. In his 2024 Rose Garden speech, quoted above, Biden mentioned each of these products by name, which indicates that the products we chose are ones elites also name. We do not message to respondents that semiconductor policy was bipartisan whereas solar panel policy was not. However, we expect that by virtue of the topic areas Republican respondents will be more prone to support semiconductor policy than solar panel policy, especially in comparison to Democrats, paralleling the behavior of Republican members of Congress.

Results

Table 1 reports the raw distribution of responses by treatment condition.

Table 1. Response distribution by treatment condition

Semiconductors

Condition	Approve	Disapprove	Neutral or don't know	(of which don't know)
Control	52.7	11.7	35.7	15.3
China	70.2	5.0	24.7	7.0
Jobs	66.0	5.3	28.7	12.2
China + Jobs	77.5	2.7	19.8	9.4

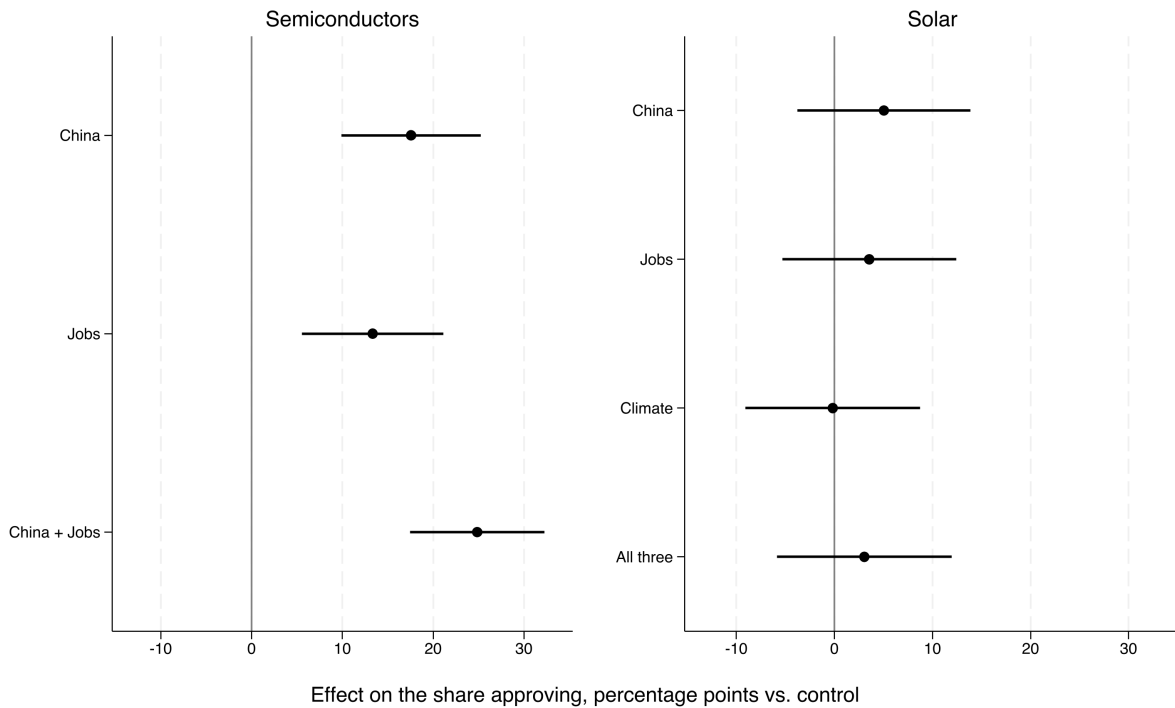
Solar

Condition	Approve	Disapprove	Neutral or don't know	(of which don't know)
Control	56.8	17.4	25.8	8.1
China	61.8	15.8	22.4	7.5
Jobs	60.3	12.8	26.9	7.9
Climate	56.6	21.9	21.5	6.6
All three	59.8	15.9	24.3	5.9

Notes: N=1200, cells report the percentage of respondents in each category.

In Figure 1 the treatment effects and their confidence intervals (based on OLS estimates reported in Table 2) are reported for factors that move support for semiconductors and solar panels, respectively. For semiconductors, the China-dependence framing has a treatment effect of 17.6 percentage points, the Jobs framing 13.3 percentage points and the China + Jobs framing 24.9 percentage points. The difference between the China-dependence and Jobs effects is not statistically significant.

Figure 1. For semiconductors, the China-dependence frame alone or in combination with jobs increases support; no significant effects for solar.



Notes: Percentage-point effect on the share approving, relative to each experiment's own control condition, with 95 percent confidence intervals. $n = 1,200$. Full results in Table A1.

Table 2. For semiconductors, the China-dependence frame simultaneously increases approval and decreases “don’t know” responses; no significant effects for solar.

Condition	Change in % approving	Change in % answering “don’t know”
Semiconductors		
China	17.6*** (3.9)	-8.3*** (2.6)
Jobs	13.3*** (4.0)	-3.1 (2.8)
China + Jobs	24.9*** (3.8)	-5.9** (2.7)
Solar		
China	5.0 (4.5)	-0.6 (2.5)
Jobs	3.6 (4.5)	-0.2 (2.5)
Climate	-0.2 (4.5)	-1.4 (2.4)
All three	3.1 (4.5)	-2.2 (2.3)

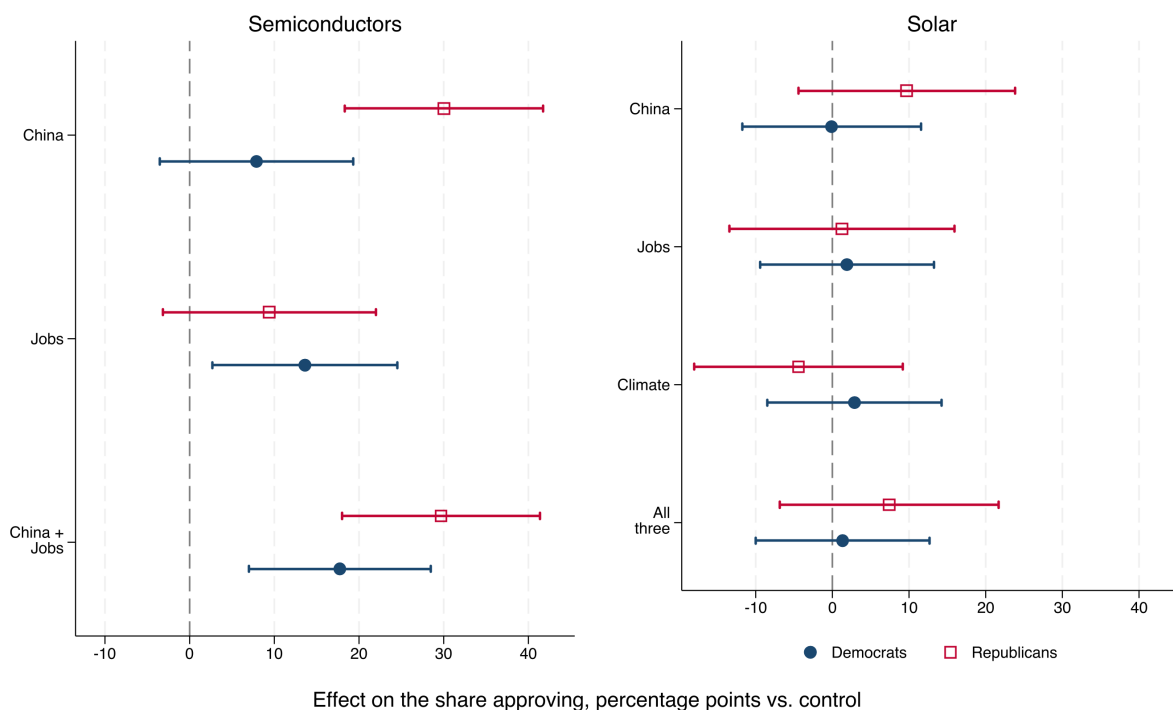
Notes: Each entry is the percentage-point difference between the named condition and the control condition in the share of respondents giving that response: OLS of the response indicator on condition indicators, robust standard errors in parentheses. Each estimate equals the difference between the corresponding cells of Table 1. No control variables, unweighted, $n = 1,200$. *** $p < .01$, ** $p < .05$, * $p < .10$.

For solar panels, none of the framings cause a significant change of opinion (see again Figure 1). With approximately 240 respondents per solar arm, each estimated effect carries a standard error of about 4.5 percentage points. The estimates rule out effects as large as those observed for semiconductors, though they cannot rule out effects of up to 9 to 14 percentage points.

To compare across experiments, we stack each respondent's semiconductor and solar responses over the three conditions the experiments share, with standard errors clustered by respondent.¹⁰ The China-dependence treatment effect on solar approval is 12.5 percentage points smaller than its effect on semiconductor approval; the difference is significant ($p = 0.039$). In contrast, the Jobs treatment effect is not significantly different across policies ($p = 0.100$).

Figure 2 breaks down framing effects by party, for the semiconductor (left panel) and solar (right panel) treatments. To set the results in context, the Control responses are as follows: 65.3% of Democrats and 49.2% of Republicans favor semiconductor policy. Solar presents a partisan contrast: 78.1% of Democrats and 39.8% we expect both parties to expect it to appeal of Republicans support the policy.

Figure 2. On semiconductors, the China-dependence frame moves Republicans far more than Democrats



Note: Percentage-point effect on the share approving, relative to control, estimated separately for each party, with 95 percent confidence intervals. $n = 1,200$. Full results in Table A2.

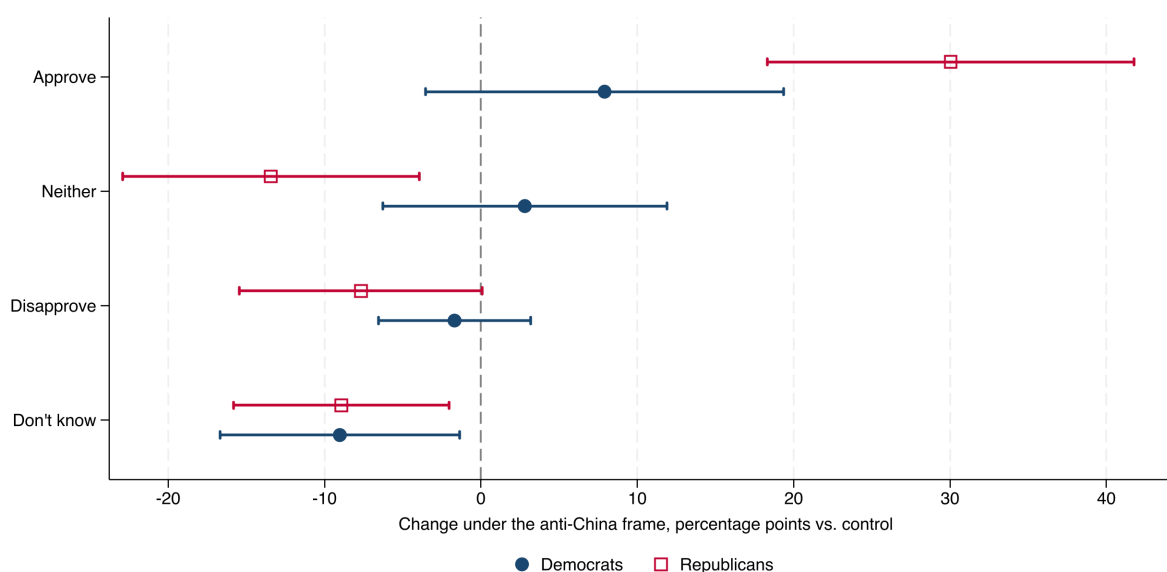
¹⁰ See replication files.

As visible in the left panel of Figure 2, Republicans are strongly and significantly moved by the China-dependence framing, but not by the jobs framing. The China-dependence frame's effect among Republicans exceeds its effect among Democrats by a statistically significant 22.1 percentage points.¹¹ Under the China-dependence frame, Republican approval reaches approximately 79 percent and the partisan gap in approval closes. Among Republicans, the China-dependence frame outperforms the jobs frame by 20.6 percentage points ($p = 0.001$). The China + Jobs framing is positive and significant for both groups of partisans.

As shown in the right panel of Figure 2, none of the three frames moves any partisan group on solar, nor does their combination. The Republican point estimate on the China-dependence frame is positive, but not significant, and confidence intervals overlap considerably with the Democratic point estimate.

Which Republicans are responding differently when given the China-dependence semiconductor treatment? Figure 3 shows that the China-dependence frame moves previously uncommitted or disapproving Republicans into approving the semiconductor policy. In contrast, the only significant shift among Democrats is a decline in “don’t know” responses. The pooled decline in “don’t know” responses is not concentrated in any one party.

Figure 3. On semiconductors, the China-dependence frame moves Republicans out of the middle category and into approval; it does not significantly raise approval among Democrats.



Note: Percentage-point change in each response category under the China-dependence frame, relative to control, semiconductors only, by party, with 95 percent confidence intervals. $n = 1,200$. Full results in Table A3.

¹¹ The smallest party difference the design can detect at 80 percent power is about 23 percentage points, so the difference we report is significant but imprecisely estimated.

To probe robustness, we consider whether treatment effects change when controlling for relevant, previously held views collected before the experiments.¹² Results are essentially unchanged when controlling for the extent to which respondents see government support for manufacturing or climate change as important issues.

Does the China-dependence frame operate differently for respondents that, pre-treatment, rated relations with China as an important issue? There is no evidence of heterogeneity in this case, either. The China-dependence frame increased approval by 17.4 percentage points among those who rated the issue important and 18.7 percentage points among those who did not, and the difference between groups is not statistically significant ($p = .88$). This null finding helps rule out one candidate explanation: if the frame worked because it matched a consideration some respondents already weighed heavily, we would have found differential effects. Future research would usefully probe other candidate explanations that remain untested here. For example, a jobs message may tell respondents nothing new about what industrial policy is for, while a dependence message supplies a new reason. Or Republicans may be differentially responding to a message that matches their own party's elite rhetoric, rather than being influenced by its content. Experimental designs built to manipulate novelty cues, content, or the messenger would help probe these questions.

Conclusion

Focusing on the Biden-era landmark CHIPS Act and Inflation Reduction Act (IRA), we field an original survey experiment to assess how framing legislation around decoupling from China affects public support, in conjunction with job creation. We find strong evidence that the China-dependence frame increases support for semiconductor policy, particularly among Republican respondents, which is notable in the deeply polarized Biden era. We do not find similar patterns for support for solar policy. Our treatments, including China-dependence, job creation, and environment framing, had little impact on support for or opposition to solar policy.

Our results highlight the potential effectiveness of using economic nationalism to motivate major policy change in the case of semiconductors. Framing policies around dependence on China was an effective strategy for garnering Republican support for semiconductor policy. Democratic elites gain out-party support for their policy from the frame, and Republican elites find their own voters responsive to it. However, this approach may carry long-term costs. Global challenges require cross-national cooperation, which can be undermined by China-dependence framing.

Even when voters are confronted with different frames, polarized policies, such as renewable energy and the Inflation Reduction Act, may leave elites little room to shape policy support, though our solar experiment cannot rule out modest effects. Republicans and Democrats were already far apart on solar before any frame was shown, which points to pre-existing partisan sorting as a condition on the frame's reach. Whether the partisan passage of the Inflation Reduction Act added to that sorting, and whether the other differences between the two industries contribute, could be uncovered by an experimental design that varies the qualities of industries rather than the framing of policies.

¹² See Appendix B for balance on observables demonstrating randomization success.

The finding we can state with confidence comes from the semiconductor experiment. Told that federal support for chip manufacturing would create jobs, Republicans did not detectably move. Told that it would reduce dependence on China, they moved about thirty points and closed the gap with Democrats. On a Democratic administration's signature policy, the out-party came across on a dependence argument and not on a jobs argument. That is the pattern elites in both parties appear to be acting on when they justify industrial policy by pointing to China.

References

- Allan, Bentley, Joanna I. Lewis, and Thomas Oatley. 2021. "Green Industrial Policy and the Global Transformation of Climate Politics." *Global Environmental Politics*, 21(4), 1-19.
- Allan, Bentley B., and Jonas Nahm. 2025. "Strategies of Green Industrial Policy: How States Position Firms in Global Supply Chains." *American Political Science Review*, 119(1), 420-434.
- Ballard-Rosa, Cameron, Judith L. Goldstein, and Nita Rudra. 2024. "Trade as Villain: Belief in the American Dream and Declining Support for Globalization." *The Journal of Politics*, 86(1), 274-290.
- Bauerle Danzman, Sarah. 2026. "Securitized Political Economy, Investment Regulation and Business Influence in a Geoeconomic Era." *European Journal of International Relations*, 32(1), 130-157.
- Carnegie, Allison, and Nikhar Gaikwad. 2022. "Public Opinion on Geopolitics and Trade: Theory and Evidence." *World Politics*, 74(2), 167-204.
- Chong, Dennis, and James N. Druckman. 2013. "Counterframing Effects." *The Journal of Politics*, 75(1), 1-16.
- Clark, Richard, Sarah Kreps, and Adi Rao. 2025. "The Political Economy of Reshoring: Evidence from the Semiconductor Industry." *PLOS ONE*, 20(2), e0316473.
- Donnelly, Shawn. 2024. "Political Party Competition and Varieties of US Economic Nationalism: Trade Wars, Industrial Policy and EU-US Relations." *Journal of European Public Policy*, 31(1), 79-103.
- Druckman, James N., Erik Peterson, and Rune Slothuus. 2013. "How Elite Partisan Polarization Affects Public Opinion Formation." *American Political Science Review*, 107(1), 57-79.
- Egan, Patrick J. 2013. *Partisan Priorities: How Issue Ownership Drives and Distorts American Politics*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Farrell, Henry, and Abraham L. Newman. 2019. "Weaponized Interdependence: How Global Economic Networks Shape State Coercion." *International Security*, 44(1), 42-79.
- Feldman, Lauren, and P. Sol Hart. 2018. "Climate Change as a Polarizing Cue: Framing Effects on Public Support for Low-Carbon Energy Policies." *Global Environmental Change*, 51, 54-66.
- Goldstein, Judith, and Robert Gulotty. 2021. "America and the Trade Regime: What Went Wrong?" *International Organization*, 75(2), 524-557.
- Guisinger, Alexandra. 2017. *American Opinion on Trade: Preferences without Politics*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Gustafson, Abel, Seth A. Rosenthal, Matthew T. Ballew, Matthew H. Goldberg, Parrish Bergquist, John E. Kotcher, Edward W. Maibach, and Anthony Leiserowitz. 2019. "The Development of Partisan Polarization over the Green New Deal." *Nature Climate Change*, 9(12), 940-944.

Juhász, Réka, Nathan Lane, and Dani Rodrik. 2024. "The New Economics of Industrial Policy." *Annual Review of Economics*, 16(1), 213-242.

Kennedy, Brian, Cary Funk, and Alec Tyson. 2023. "Majorities of Americans Prioritize Renewable Energy, Back Steps to Address Climate Change." Washington, DC: Pew Research Center.

Luo, Yadong, and Ari Van Assche. 2023. "The Rise of Techno-Geopolitical Uncertainty: Implications of the United States CHIPS and Science Act." *Journal of International Business Studies*, 54(8), 1423-1440.

Mansfield, Edward D., and Diana C. Mutz. 2009. "Support for Free Trade: Self-Interest, Sociotropic Politics, and Out-Group Anxiety." *International Organization*, 63(3), 425-457.

Mayer, Adam, and E. Keith Smith. 2024. "Can Solar Energy Become Polarized? Understanding the Role of Expressive and Negative Partisanship in Support for Solar Tax Credits." *Energy Research & Social Science*, 113, 103545.

Osgood, Iain. 2023. "Representation and Reward: The Left-Wing Anti-Globalization Alliance, Contributions, and the Congress." *Review of International Political Economy*, 30(3), 991-1016.

Petrocik, John R. 1996. "Issue Ownership in Presidential Elections, with a 1980 Case Study." *American Journal of Political Science*, 40(3), 825-850.

Rodrik, Dani. 2014. "Green Industrial Policy." *Oxford Review of Economic Policy*, 30(3), 469-491.

Stokes, Leah C., and Christopher Warshaw. 2017. "Renewable Energy Policy Design and Framing Influence Public Support in the United States." *Nature Energy*, 2(8), 17107.

Sutter, Karen M., John F. Sargent Jr., and Manpreet Singh. 2023. "Semiconductors and the CHIPS Act: The Global Context." Washington, DC: Congressional Research Service.

Walter, Stefanie. 2021. "The Backlash Against Globalization." *Annual Review of Political Science*, 24(1), 421-442.

Weiss, Linda. 2014. *America Inc.? Innovation and Enterprise in the National Security State*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.

Wijaya, Trissia, and Kanishka Jayasuriya. 2024. "Militarised Neoliberalism and the Reconstruction of the Global Political Economy." *New Political Economy*, 29(4), 546-559.

Appendix

Appendix A. Full regression results behind the figures

Table A1. Models behind Figure 1

Term	Semiconductors	Solar
China	17.57*** (3.92)	5.05 (4.50)
Jobs	13.34*** (3.97)	3.55 (4.51)
China + Jobs	24.85*** (3.77)	
Climate		-0.17 (4.54)
All three		3.05 (4.53)
Constant (control)	52.67*** (2.89)	56.78*** (3.23)
Respondents	1200	1200
R-squared	0.037	0.002

Table A2. Models behind Figure 2

Term	Semiconductors	Solar
China	7.91 (5.83)	-0.12 (5.95)
Jobs	13.62** (5.57)	1.88 (5.78)
China + Jobs	17.74*** (5.47)	
Climate		2.88 (5.80)
All three		1.31 (5.79)
Republican	-16.12** (6.20)	-38.33*** (6.54)
Other	-35.32*** (7.80)	-30.51*** (8.84)
China x Republican	22.13*** (8.35)	9.79 (9.35)
China x Other	12.09 (10.71)	4.59 (12.17)
Jobs x Republican	-4.21 (8.50)	-0.65 (9.47)
Jobs x Other	6.38 (10.97)	1.35 (11.68)
China + Jobs x Republican	11.95 (8.09)	
China + Jobs x Other	16.87 (10.39)	
Climate x Republican		-7.32 (9.04)
Climate x Other		-1.66 (12.35)
All three x Republican		6.08 (9.31)
All three x Other		-11.72 (12.19)
Constant (control, Democrats)	65.32*** (4.30)	78.12*** (4.25)
Respondents	1200	1200
R-squared	0.089	0.133

Table A3. Models behind Figure 3

Term	Approve	Neither	DontKnow	Disapprove
China	7.91 (5.83)	2.81 (4.64)	-9.02** (3.91)	-1.69 (2.49)
Jobs	13.62** (5.57)	1.27 (4.50)	-10.81*** (3.72)	-4.09** (2.08)
China + Jobs	17.74*** (5.47)	-8.06** (3.88)	-7.26* (4.08)	-2.42 (2.38)
Republican	-16.12** (6.20)	9.29* (4.96)	-2.62 (4.41)	9.45** (3.68)
Other	-35.32*** (7.80)	11.48 (7.00)	6.68 (6.73)	17.16*** (6.20)
China x Republican	22.13*** (8.35)	-16.24** (6.70)	0.10 (5.25)	-5.99 (4.68)
China x Other	12.09 (10.71)	1.50 (9.63)	0.66 (8.24)	-14.25** (7.04)
Jobs x Republican	-4.21 (8.50)	-6.12 (6.94)	10.18* (5.65)	0.15 (4.71)
Jobs x Other	6.38 (10.97)	-14.31 (8.95)	20.29** (9.43)	-12.36* (6.99)
China + Jobs x Republican	11.95 (8.09)	-3.82 (6.27)	1.90 (5.64)	-10.03** (4.14)
China + Jobs x Other	16.87 (10.39)	-2.55 (8.61)	0.64 (8.46)	-14.97** (6.87)
Constant (control, Democrats)	65.32*** (4.30)	14.52*** (3.18)	15.32*** (3.25)	4.84** (1.94)
Respondents	1200	1200	1200	1200

R-squared	0.089	0.027	0.042	0.046
------------------	--------------	--------------	--------------	--------------

*Note: Every coefficient in each model. OLS with robust standard errors, no control variables, unweighted. Percentage points, standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < .01$, ** $p < .05$, * $p < .10$. Omitted categories are the control condition and Democrats, so the constant is control-group approval among Democrats. Other pools pure Independents and Not sure.*

Appendix B. Covariate balance

Table B1. Semiconductor experiment

Variable	Control	China	Jobs	China + Jobs
18–29	0.187 (0.023)	0.167 (0.022)	0.182 (0.022)	0.164 (0.022)
65 or older	0.260 (0.025)	0.214 (0.024)	0.221 (0.024)	0.221 (0.024)
Woman	0.533 (0.029)	0.495 (0.029)	0.521 (0.029)	0.530 (0.029)
White	0.700 (0.027)	0.676 (0.027)	0.706 (0.026)	0.658 (0.028)
College degree	0.337 (0.027)	0.328 (0.027)	0.347 (0.027)	0.359 (0.028)
Family income (1–16)	6.789 (0.236)	6.891 (0.224)	6.380 (0.219)	6.692 (0.224)
Declined to report income	0.100 (0.017)	0.077 (0.015)	0.096 (0.017)	0.128 (0.019)
Homeowner	0.690 (0.027)	0.672 (0.027)	0.647 (0.028)	0.644 (0.028)
Union household	0.170 (0.022)	0.187 (0.023)	0.198 (0.023)	0.164 (0.022)
Employed	0.493 (0.029)	0.512 (0.029)	0.505 (0.029)	0.517 (0.029)
Retired	0.220 (0.024)	0.211 (0.024)	0.205 (0.023)	0.185 (0.023)
Follows news most of the time	0.467 (0.029)	0.445 (0.029)	0.449 (0.029)	0.503 (0.029)
Rural	0.253 (0.025)	0.197 (0.023)	0.224 (0.024)	0.215 (0.024)
Democrat	0.413 (0.028)	0.425 (0.029)	0.439 (0.029)	0.416 (0.029)
Republican	0.420 (0.029)	0.355 (0.028)	0.383 (0.028)	0.366 (0.028)
Conservative	0.373 (0.028)	0.311 (0.027)	0.327 (0.027)	0.336 (0.027)
No ideological identification	0.080 (0.016)	0.084 (0.016)	0.076 (0.015)	0.070 (0.015)
Respondents	300	299	303	298

Table B2. Solar experiment

Variable	Control	China	Jobs	Climate	All three
18–29	0.161 (0.024)	0.112 (0.020)	0.215 (0.026)	0.194 (0.025)	0.192 (0.026)
65 or older	0.271 (0.029)	0.274 (0.029)	0.161 (0.024)	0.231 (0.027)	0.209 (0.026)
Woman	0.530 (0.033)	0.535 (0.032)	0.479 (0.032)	0.541 (0.032)	0.515 (0.032)
White	0.636 (0.031)	0.743 (0.028)	0.686 (0.030)	0.653 (0.031)	0.707 (0.029)
College degree	0.318 (0.030)	0.373 (0.031)	0.335 (0.030)	0.368 (0.031)	0.318 (0.030)
Family income (1–16)	6.684 (0.253)	6.822 (0.251)	6.292 (0.258)	6.893 (0.252)	6.748 (0.250)
Declined to report income	0.102 (0.020)	0.091 (0.019)	0.107 (0.020)	0.112 (0.020)	0.088 (0.018)
Homeowner	0.691 (0.030)	0.710 (0.029)	0.587 (0.032)	0.653 (0.031)	0.678 (0.030)
Union household	0.186 (0.025)	0.162 (0.024)	0.198 (0.026)	0.161 (0.024)	0.192 (0.026)
Employed	0.513 (0.033)	0.481 (0.032)	0.554 (0.032)	0.475 (0.032)	0.510 (0.032)
Retired	0.216 (0.027)	0.257 (0.028)	0.149 (0.023)	0.223 (0.027)	0.180 (0.025)
Follows news most of the time	0.453 (0.032)	0.494 (0.032)	0.417 (0.032)	0.508 (0.032)	0.456 (0.032)
Rural	0.195 (0.026)	0.282 (0.029)	0.215 (0.026)	0.215 (0.026)	0.205 (0.026)
Democrat	0.407 (0.032)	0.415 (0.032)	0.434 (0.032)	0.413 (0.032)	0.448 (0.032)
Republican	0.415 (0.032)	0.386 (0.031)	0.322 (0.030)	0.409 (0.032)	0.372 (0.031)
Conservative	0.360 (0.031)	0.373 (0.031)	0.281 (0.029)	0.335 (0.030)	0.335 (0.031)
No ideological identification	0.097 (0.019)	0.062 (0.016)	0.066 (0.016)	0.074 (0.017)	0.088 (0.018)
Respondents	236	241	242	242	239

Note: Condition means with standard errors in parentheses; $n = 1,200$. Assignment is not predictable from all thirteen covariates jointly (categorical covariates are entered as sets of indicators and shown in the table by their main categories), LR chi-square(90) = 74.19, $p = 0.886$ for semiconductors and LR chi-square(120) = 109.31, $p = 0.748$ for solar. Two of twenty-six single-covariate tests reject at the ten percent level, homeowner and age group, both in the solar experiment.